



Big shots: If he meets Jannik Sinner in the final, Carlos Alcaraz must focus on how to both absorb and counteract the Italian's ferocious power. GETTYIMAGES

season at the U.S. Open. "The good news for Taylor Fritz," said *Tennis Channel* analyst Paul Annacone, "is that his average level is unbelievably high now." That should be good enough to propel him again to the Open semis.

Jack Draper — Before overpowering De Minaur in the 2024 U.S. Open quarterfinals, Draper confided he considered quitting the sport because the former junior star did not think he could compete with the big boys on the ATP Tour. That all changed last year when he whipped the likes of Alcaraz, Sinner, Fritz, Holger Rune, and Stefanos Tsitsipas, and captured his first title at Stuttgart. In sports parlance, Draper has 'a high ceiling' and proved it again this season with wins over Alcaraz, Fritz, Rune, Shelton, and Joao Fonseca to capture his most prestigious crown at Indian Wells.

Draper, 23, has plenty of weapons, starting with a wicked lefty serve that he blasts, slices, and kicks superbly. His aggressive topspin forehand and rock-solid two-handed backhand allow him to hang in there with baseline blasters. And his strong volleys and smashes decisively finish off rallies. Do not be surprised if the handsome Brit makes the U.S. Open semis again.

Andrey Rublev — The 27-year-old Russian (**left**) falls into the 'best of the rest' category, as his inability to beat the best and advance past the quarters at the Majors attests. A baseline basher with a monster forehand and an improved first serve, Rublev has three weaknesses: an attackable second serve, a mediocre net game, and a Vesuvian temper that can explode at any time.

After he was disqualified for screaming at a line judge in the 2024 Dubai semis, he shared his mental health problems with *The National* newspaper in a candid interview. "I was in a loop, lost with myself for a couple of years of, I don't know, not



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